On the following day, November 1, Statsenko received another order: load the missiles on the ships first; everything else, including the servicemen, could wait. The missiles, which were to be out of Cuba by November 10, began their trip back to the seashore, now in daytime and without the escort of the Cuban police. They left their bases much faster than they had arrived. By November 2 the first R-12 ballistic missiles were already in the Cuban ports, waiting to be loaded onto the decks and into the ships' holds. There were at least a dozen Soviet ships stranded in Cuba after the introduction of the American blockade, but few of them were capable of carrying the missiles. Still, eight ships were designated for the task.

Loading began on November 3 and lasted until the 8th. "The dispatch of the missiles took place under particularly complicated and difficult conditions. Circumstances were such that there were old-model ships in Cuba at the time, their decks encumbered with various superstructures; cranes that could handle heavy cargoes were generally lacking, and the ports where the loading took place were poorly supplied with cranes," reported Statsenko after his return to the Soviet Union. "The loading of the ships went on nonstop, day and night."[20]

In parallel, the servicemen were loading the warheads for the R-15 missiles on the *Aleksandrovsk*, which had brought warheads for R-14 medium-range missiles to Cuba, although the missiles themselves never reached the island because of the blockade. The *Aleksandrovsk* had managed to make it to Cuba a few hours before the imposition of the blockade and was docked for the duration, its nuclear cargo never unloaded —a perfect target for a possible American air strike.

On October 27, the most dangerous day of the crisis, Malinovsky ordered Pliev to send the *Aleksandrovsk* home with its nuclear payload as soon as possible. But the ship's departure was delayed because on the next day Malinovsky issued another order to Pliev: "We have made the decision to dismantle the R-12s and remove them. Begin to implement this measure." The departure of the *Aleksandrovsk* was postponed, and two days later, on October 30, Malinovsky issued yet another order: "Load warheads for R-12 on the *Aleksandrovsk* and send the transport accompanied by the ready ship to the Soviet Union."[21]